

Regeneration



One tree, split down the trunk. Dead wood on one side, leaves on the other. Same roots, two conditions. The life is not a coat of paint on the dead half.

OPEN PART IV BY SAYING

Christ's work is finished. It does not land on a person by magic. The Spirit gives life, seals, adopts, and rescues. He brings sinners to faith and repentance, then keeps making them like Jesus. These weeks are about how the gospel gets inside a real person.

Before you gather

- Read Day 21, Regeneration, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read John 3:3–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What have you seen that looked fine on the outside and was dead on the inside?

Leader. Dead versus alive. The book already asked what changed when they came to Christ, and what to put off from 2 Corinthians 5:17. Do not retake that journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This tree did not try harder. God makes the dead alive. Regeneration is the Spirit's work of new birth, not self-improvement. You do not achieve it. He raises you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Regeneration is being born again through the Holy Spirit. It is a supernatural work of God in which a spiritually dead person is made alive.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek palingenesia — rebirth, regeneration. Also zōopoieō — to make alive.

MEMORY VERSE • TITUS 3:5

He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Regeneration. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

John 3:3–8

Titus 3:5 is the memory verse. John 3 puts Jesus in front of a religious man: unless you are born from above, you cannot see the kingdom. The Spirit gives that life by the Word. He is not steered by our feelings.

Jesus answered him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God." Nicodemus said to him, "How can a man be born when he is old?" ... Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. Do not marvel that I said to you, 'You must be born again.' The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Nicodemus is a serious religious teacher. What does Jesus say he still cannot do unless he is born again? **CORE**

Leader. See and enter the kingdom of God. Religion without new birth leaves him outside. God must make the dead alive (John 3; Ephesians 2:1–5). Competence is not life.

2. Jesus compares the Spirit to the wind. What can you observe, and what can you not command?

Leader. You hear the sound and see the effects. You do not steer the Spirit. New birth is God's act through the Word, not an inner impression we produce.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ezekiel 36:26–27 promises a new heart and God's Spirit, causing people to walk in His ways. How is that different from deciding to improve the old heart? **CORE**

Leader. God does not coach the dead. He gives a new heart. Obedience follows that life. It does not create it. Titus 3:5: mercy, not works done by us in righteousness.

4. Titus 3:5 says the washing of regeneration is His mercy, not works done by us in righteousness. What "works" do people still offer as the reason God made them alive?

Leader. A prayer said well, a raised hand, a moral cleanup before believing. Those may come along with the gospel. They do not cause the new birth.

5. John 3:8 says you hear the sound. What is the sound of new birth in an ordinary week?

Leader. Hunger for the Word, a conscience that tells the truth, love for Christ's people. Do not follow a feeling, and do not rank quiet stories against loud ones. Look for the life God gives.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Regeneration means God makes a dead sinner alive by the Holy Spirit. New birth is His work, not self-improvement.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Pray by name for one person still dead in sin, and do one concrete kindness for them this week. Tell them Jesus Christ makes the dead alive. New birth is God's work, not a self-improvement plan.

Leader. Get the name said in the room and written down. Next week, ask who they prayed for. The sentence names Christ. The kindness is not the new birth. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God for making any of us alive in Christ when we were dead in sin.
2. Ask Him to give life, through the gospel, to the person you named.
3. Ask that obedience would follow the new heart, not try to earn it.

Before you stumble

Read the Part IV line: the Spirit changes us from the inside out. "Born of water and the Spirit" has been argued for centuries. Do not spend the night on baptism. If you must, one sentence: Jesus means the cleansing new birth the Spirit gives. Baptism signifies it. It does not replace the Spirit. If you are unsure, say, "We will not settle that side question tonight," and stay here: the dead must be made alive, and only God does it (John 3; Ephesians 2:1–5; Titus 3:5). Do not call a sad believer spiritually dead because they feel flat. Ask whether they trust Christ. Feelings are not the test. The Word is.

WITH STUDENTS

Nicodemus thought being an insider was enough. Ask what students trust instead of new birth: a Christian home, camp, a clean record. Then read John 3:3

again. God must make them alive.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23. Born again to a living hope, through the living and abiding word of God. The Spirit uses the Word. He does not bypass it for a private voice.